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CRIMEA: GREEK PORTS, MOUNTAIN TOWNS AND STEPPE EMPIRES

Population and Settlement on the Crimean Peninsula

10 November 2026 - Aust Kätzchen | austkaeztchen@confoederatio.org

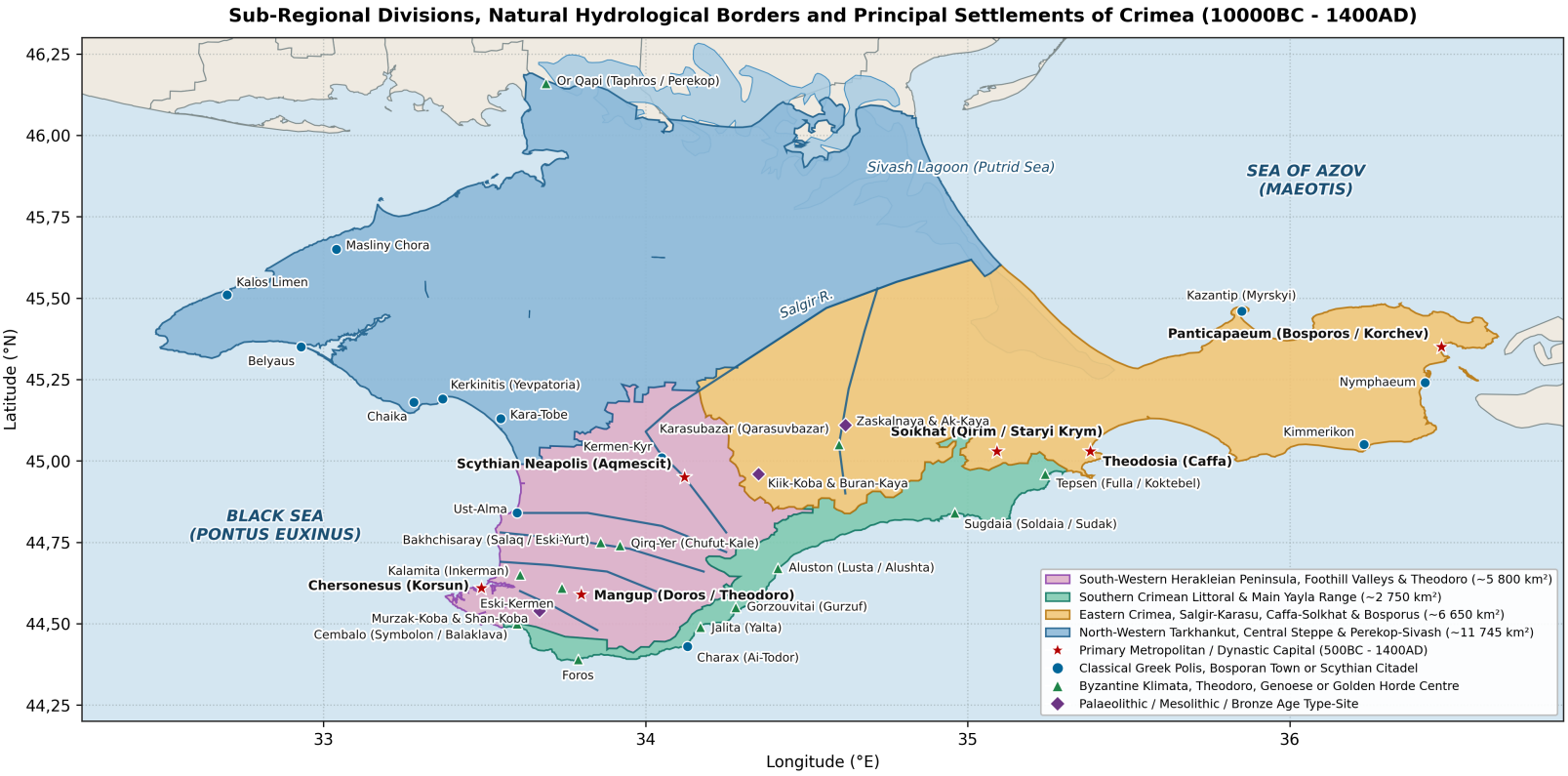


Figure 1. The four geographical divisions of Crimea (~26,95k km^2), separating the northern Tarkhankut and Sivash steppes from the south-western mountain plateaus, the sheltered southern coast and the eastern Bosporan and Solkhat-Caffa heartland.

Abstract

The Crimean Peninsula (*Taurica*, ~26,95k km^2) juts out into the Black Sea (*Pontus Euxinus*), bordered on the north-east by the shallow Sea of Azov (*Palus Maeotis*) and the Sivash lagoons and on the east by the Kerch Strait (*Kimmerian Bosporus*). Linked to the mainland steppe only by the 7 km-wide Perekop Isthmus (*Taphros/Or Qapi*) and the narrow Arabat Spit, Crimea divides naturally into three zones: the northern and central dry steppe (~72% of the land area), the three parallel ridges of the Crimean Mountains (the Outer, Inner and Main *Yayla* ranges, rising to 1,55k m at Roman-Kosh) cut by the Chorna, Belbek, Kacha, Alma, Salgir and Biyuk-Karasu valleys, and the sheltered southern coast. Small Mesolithic hunting bands (1,2k in 10000BC) and Bronze Age herders and farmers (48k by 1000BC) gave way after 600BC to Greek coastal colonies and the Bosporan and Late Scythian kingdoms, which carried the population to a Classical peak of 225k in 200AD. Gothic and Hunnic raids nearly halved numbers to 115k by 400AD, before Byzantine

forts along the coast and in the mountain plateau towns, together with new rural settlement under Khazar rule, restored the total to 215k in 900AD. After a dip during the Pecheneg and Cuman centuries, Black Sea trade through Genoese Caffa and the Golden Horde capital of Solkhat lifted Crimea to a medieval peak of 250k in 1300AD. Plague after 1346AD, civil wars in the Golden Horde and the raids of Timur and Edigu then cut the population back to 185k by 1400AD.

Background

Following its relief, river basins and historical borders, Crimea divides into four parts (Table 1). The south-west (~5,8k km^2) lies north-west of the Western Main Yayla crest and takes in the Herakleian Peninsula (*Chersonesus Taurica*/*Korsun*), the Chorna, Belbek, Kacha, Alma and Upper Salgir foothill valleys, the flat-topped limestone plateaus of the Inner Range (Mangup-Doros, Eski-Kermen, Chufut-Kale/*Qirq-Yer*, Bakla, Tepe-Kermen, Kachi-Kalyon and Kalamita) and the Bakhchisaray and Simferopol (*Scythian Neapolis*) basins.

The southern coast and Main Yayla range (~2,75k km^2) runs south-east of the Main Yayla watershed (Ai-Petri, Yalta, Babugan, Chatyr-Dag, Demerdzhi and Karabi *Yaylas*), taking in the narrow coastal bays from Cembalo (Symbolon/Balaklava) and Foros eastward past Simeiz, Alupka, Charax, Oreanda, Jalita (Yalta), Gorzouvitai (Gurzuf), Partenit, Lambat and Aluston (*Lusta*/Alushta) to Sugdaia (*Soldaia*/Sudak). In the Middle Ages this coast formed the Byzantine *Parathalassia* (*Klimata*) and the Genoese *Capitanate of Gotthia*.

Eastern Crimea (~6,65k km^2) lies south-east of the Salgir River and covers the Biyuk-Karasu valley (Karasubazar), the Golden Horde capital of Solkhat (*Qirim*/Staryi Krym), the bay of Feodosia (*Theodosia*/*Caffa*), the Karadag-Koktebel (*Tepsen*) coast and the European core of the Bosporan Kingdom on the Kerch Peninsula (Panticapaeum/*Bosporos*/*Korchev*, Nymphaeum, Myrmekion, Tyritake, Kimmerikon, Kytaia, Akra and the rural hinterland behind the Uzunlarsky and Tyritake earthworks). Finally, the north-western and central steppe (~11,75k km^2) lies north-west of the Salgir and north of the Outer Ridge foothills, covering the limestone coast of the Tarkhankut Peninsula with its Chersonesean farmsteads and ports (Kerkinitis, Kalos Limen, Chaika, Belyaus, Panskoye I, Masliny, Kara-Tobe, Kulchuk and Tarpanchi), the central dry steppe and the northern gateway at Perekop (*Taphros*/*Or Qapi*) and the Sivash lagoons.

Region	Area (% Share)	Main Settlements & Sites	Key Benchmark Populations
South-Western Herakleian, Foothills & Theodoro	5,8k km^2 (21,5%)	Chersonesus (Korsun), Scythian Neapolis, Mangup (Theodoro), Qirq-Yer (Chufut-Kale), Eski-Kermen, Kalamita	17,5k (1000BC); 78k (200AD); 74k (900AD); 78k (1300AD); 62k (1400AD)
Southern Coast & Main Yayla	2,75k km^2 (10,2%)	Cembalo (Symbolon), Foros, Charax, Jalita (Yalta), Gorzouvitai (Gurzuf), Partenit, Aluston, Sugdaia (Soldaia)	7k (1000BC); 19k (200AD); 36k (900AD); 46k (1300AD); 36k (1400AD)
Eastern Crimea, Caffa-Solkhat & Bosporus	6,65k km^2 (24,7%)	Panticapaeum (Bosporos/ Korchev), Theodosia (Caffa), Solkhat (Qirim), Karasubazar, Nymphaeum, Ilurat, Tepsen	13k (1000BC); 94k (200AD); 77k (900AD); 96k (1300AD); 65k (1400AD)
North-Western Tarkhankut & Central Steppe	11,75k km^2 (43,6%)	Kerkinitis, Kalos Limen, Belyaus, Panskoye I, Masliny, Chaika, Kara-Tobe, Kulchuk, Or Qapi (Taphros/Perekop)	10,5k (1000BC); 34k (200AD); 28k (900AD); 30k (1300AD); 22k (1400AD)

Total Crimean Peninsula	26,95k km^2 (100%)	171 recorded settlements and sites	48k (1000BC); 225k (200AD); 215k (900AD); 250k (1300AD); 185k (1400AD)

Table 1. The four geographical divisions of Crimea (26,95k km^2), comparing land area, principal settlements and population totals from the Late Bronze Age (1000BC) to 1400AD.

Results

Prehistory and the Early Iron Age

Mesolithic and Neolithic Hunters and Herders

At the end of the Ice Age (10000BC - 8000BC), when the Black Sea stood 60 to 80 metres below its modern level as the freshwater Neoeuxine lake, settlement in Crimea clustered in the limestone rock-shelters (*grottoes*) of the Inner Ridge and the Chornaya, Belbek, Kacha and Zuya river gorges [1][2]. Upper Palaeolithic camps such as Buran-Kaya III (on the Burulcha), Siuren I (on the Belbek), Kabazi II, Zaskalnaya and Kiik-Koba were followed by two successive Mesolithic cultures studied by G. A. Bonch-Osmolovsky, S. N. Bibikov and D. Ya. Telegin [3][4].

The Shan-Koba Culture (c. 10000-7500BC) is marked by crescent-shaped flint microliths and the hunting of red deer, saiga antelope, wild boar and wild horses at Shan-Koba, Fatma-Koba Layer 6, Grot Skalisty (on the Bodrak), Zamil-Koba I and Buran-Kaya III [3]. Across the river gorges and the wide coastal plain, small hunting bands of 35 to 80 people supported a population of about 1,2k in 10000BC, rising to 2,1k by 8000BC as warmer weather spread oak and pistachio woods through the foothill valleys.

The Murzak-Koba Culture (7500-5500BC) and the Crimean Neolithic (6000-5000BC) are known from excavations at Murzak-Koba in the Chornaya gorge, Fatma-Koba, Laspi VII on the south coast, Tash-Air I in the Kacha canyon, Kaya-Arasy near Bakhchisaray, At-Bash on the Ai-Petri *Yayla* and Frontovoye I on the Kerch Peninsula. These sites show a shift toward trapeze-shaped flints, land-snail gathering, sea fishing and the first keeping of pigs, sheep and goats [1][3][4]. By 6000BC the population reached 3,5k, nearly doubling to 6,5k in 5000BC as permanent open-air villages appeared at Tash-Air I, Kaya-Arasy, Alekseevka on the Tarkhankut Peninsula and Frontovoye.

Bronze Age Herders and the Tauri

Between 4000BC and 2000BC, Crimea linked the kurgan herders of the Pontic steppe (Sredny Stog, Yamnaya and Catacomb cultures) with the metalworking peoples of the North Caucasus [5][6]. In the Early and Middle Bronze Age (3200-2200BC), the local Kemi-Oba Culture occupied the foothill valleys from Sevastopol to the Salgir and Biyuk-Karasu basins. Kemi-Oba communities built timber-and-stone cist graves painted with red ochre patterns, set up carved stone stelae (*Bakhchi-Eli* and *Kazanki*) and combined valley farming with summer grazing on the high *Yayla* pastures [5][6]. Together with Yamnaya and Catacomb groups on the Kerch Peninsula (Kamenka-Bosporan and Planerskoye) and the Tarkhankut-Sivash steppes, Kemi-Oba settlements (7,5k in 3000BC and 12k in 2000BC in the south-western foothills) raised Crimea's total population from 11k in 4000BC to 22k in 3000BC and 35k in 2000BC.

During the Late Bronze Age and Early Iron Age (1500-800BC), Sabatinovka and Belozerka farming villages in the steppe lived alongside the Kizil-Koba Culture of the mountains and foothills, which Kh. I. Kris and

V. A. Kolotukhin identify with the Tauri (*Tauroi*) of Herodotus (*Histories* IV.99-103) and Euripides [7][8][9]. Centred on the 12 ha fortified promontory of Uch-Bash near Inkerman (0,9k - 1,2k inhabitants), Kizil-Koba (*Krasnaya Peshchera*) in the Upper Salgir valley, Druzhnoye, Tash-Dzhargan and the stone-box (*ashchechnye*) cemeteries of the Baidar valley and southern coast (Malorechenskoye, Oreanda, Simeiz and Gurzuf), Tauri and steppe communities supported 48k people in 1000BC (17,5k in the south-western foothills, 7k along the southern coast, 13k in eastern Crimea and 10,5k across the north-western steppe).

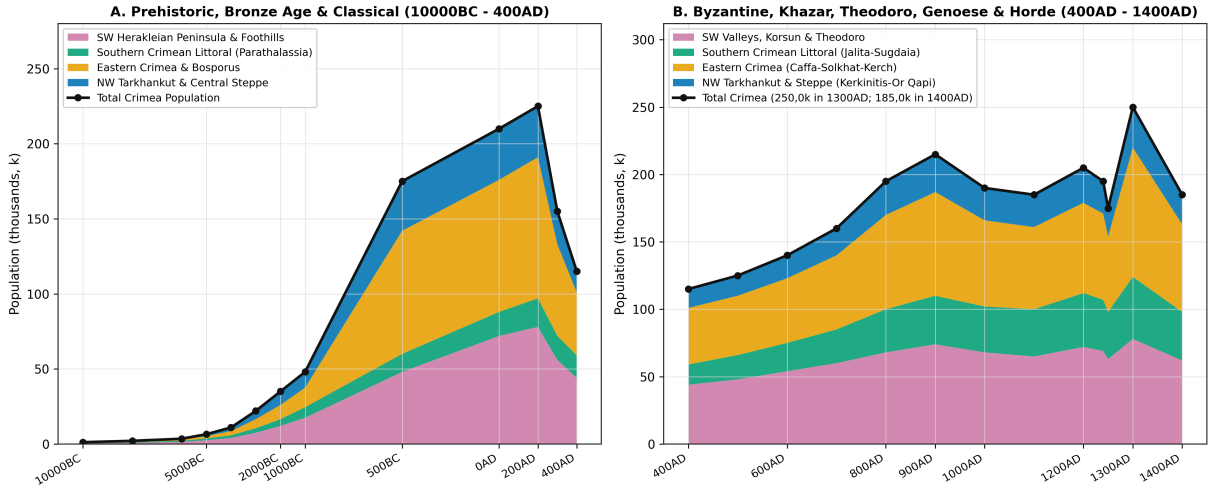


Figure 2. Total and regional population of Crimea from 10000BC to 1400AD, showing the three main peaks under the Classical Bosporan Kingdom and Chersonesus (225k in 200AD), Byzantine and Khazar rule (215k in 900AD) and Golden Horde Solkhat and Genoese Caffa (250k in 1300AD).

Classical Antiquity

The Bosporan Kingdom and Chersonesus

Greek settlement in the sixth and fifth centuries BC set off the first rapid growth in Crimean history, lifting the population from 48k in 1000BC to 175k in 500BC and 210k at 0AD [10][11][12]. Two colonial networks reshaped the peninsula.

In eastern Crimea (82k in 500BC; 88k in 0AD; 94k in 200AD), colonists from Miletus founded Panticapaeum (modern Kerch) on Mount Mithridates c. 600BC. As capital of the Archaeanactid (480BC) and Spartocid (438-108BC) kings of the Bosporus, Panticapaeum grew to ~100 ha of terraced acropolis, agora, craft quarters and harbour suburbs with 22k to 28k inhabitants [10][13]. Around it along the Kerch Strait and Azov-Black Sea coasts stood a ring of Greek towns: Theodosia (annexed by Leucon I c. 380BC as a grain port, 6k in 500BC), Nymphaeum (4,5k), Myrmekion (3,5k), Tyritake (3,2k - 4k), Kimmerikon (2,5k - 3k), Kytaia (2,2k - 2,9k), Porthmion (1,8k), Akra (1,5k - 1,9k) and Zenon's Chersonesus (1,4k - 2,1k). Behind the Tyritake and Uzunlarsky earth ramparts (36 km from the Sea of Azov to Lake Uzunlar), the Kerch interior held over 280 rural estates and fortified villages (Andreevka-Yuzhnaya, Generalskoye-Zapadnoye, Polyanka, Zolotoe, Tasunovo, Mikhailovka, Artesian and Ilurat), which under Leucon I shipped 400k *medimnoi* (~16,5k tonnes) of wheat a year to Athens [10][14].

In south-western and north-western Crimea (48k and 33k in 500BC), settlers from Heraclea Pontica founded Dorian Chersonesus Taurica in 422/421BC on Quarantine Bay over an earlier sixth-century Ionian trading post. Built on a 38 ha street grid inside ashlar walls, Chersonesus grew from 4,5k inhabitants in 500BC to 16k in 0AD and 20k in 200AD [15][16]. Across the Herakleian Peninsula (~10k ha), G. M.

Nikolaenko and J. C. Carter have mapped 415 stone-walled farm plots (*kleroi* of 26,5 ha each, planted with vines and fruit trees around stone farmhouse towers), which supported a rural population of 6k to 8k [12][17]. In the mid-fourth century BC, Chersonesus also took over the north-western coast along the Tarkhankut Peninsula, including the older Ionian town of Kerkinitis (Yevpatoria, 8,5 ha, 4,2k in 500BC), Kalos Limen (Chornomorske, 2,5k - 2,8k) and dozens of fortified coastal farms and grain depots at Panskoye I, Belyaus, Chaika, Masliny, Kara-Tobe, Kulchuk, Tarpanchi and Dzhangul [11][18][19].

Late Scythia and the Roman Garrison

Pushed south by Sarmatian tribes crossing the Don in the third and second centuries BC, Royal Scythian rulers built a new Late Scythian kingdom in the Crimean foothills (*Scythia Minor*) around their walled capital at Scythian Neapolis (*Kermen-Chuk*, a 20 ha fortress in modern Simferopol with 7,5k - 8k inhabitants in 0AD - 200AD) [20][21][22]. Kings Skilurus and Palakus seized the north-western Chersonesean coast (taking Kerkinitis, Kalos Limen, Chaika, Belyaus and Tarpanchi) and built over 50 hillforts along the Alma, Kacha, Belbek and Salgir rivers, led by the coastal fort of Ust-Alma (Palakion, 6 ha, 3,5k - 4k), Kermen-Kyr (Chabion, 2,8k), Bulganak (Khaboi, 2,5k), Alma-Kermen (2,2k), Belogorsk-Ak-Kaya (2,8k), Zayachye (1,5k) and Dobroye (1,6k) [18][21][23].

In 110-107BC Diophantus, general of Mithridates VI Eupator, rescued Chersonesus and brought Crimea into the Pontic kingdom before Rome established its protectorate after 63BC [16]. From the first to the third centuries AD, Rome stationed troops from Legions *I Italica*, *V Macedonica* and *XI Claudia* and warships of the *Classis Flavia Moesica* at Chersonesus, Balaklava-Kadykovka (Symbolon) and the cliff-top fort of Charax on Cape Ai-Todor (1,8k soldiers and camp followers in 200AD) [16][24]. At the same time, the Bosporan kings built heavy stone forts across the Kerch interior to block steppe raids (Ilurat at 2,6k, Artesian at 2,1k, Mikhailovka at 1,8k and Tasunovo at 1,3k), carrying Crimea to its Classical peak of 225k in 200AD (78k in the south-west, 19k on the south coast, 94k in the east and 34k in the north-west) [10][13].

Gothic and Borani sea raids in 252-275AD (which sacked Tanais, Gorgippia, Ilurat, Myrmekion and the Late Scythian foothill forts) and the Hunnic crossing of the Kerch Strait in 370-376AD (which destroyed the Bosporan countryside, Scythian Neapolis and Ust-Alma) brought a steep drop in numbers [23][25]. The population fell to 155k in 300AD and 115k in 400AD - nearly half its 200AD level - as survivors fled behind the walls of Chersonesus and Bosporos or into the wooded mountain valleys, where the Alanic and Gothic cemeteries of Neyzats, Opushki, Druzhnoye, Suuk-Su and Luchistoye mark the beginnings of medieval Crimean Gothia [25].

Medieval Crimea

Byzantine Cherson, Gothia and the Khazars

Under Justinian I (527-565AD) and Maurice (582-602AD), Byzantium rebuilt the walls of Chersonesus (*Cherson*) and Bosporos, put up the coastal forts of Aluston (Alushta) and Gorzouvitai (Gurzuf) and closed the mountain passes around the Gothic-Alanic country of *Dory* with stone barrier walls [25][26]. Along the Inner Ridge of south-western Crimea, Byzantine engineers and Christian Gothic-Alanic settlers founded the cliff-top “cave-towns” (*peshchernye goroda*): Mangup-Doros (a 90 ha plateau stronghold that grew from 2,5k in 500AD to 7k in 900AD), Eski-Kermen (an 18 ha plateau, rising from 2,8k in 600AD to 5,2k in 900AD), Chufut-Kale (*Qirq-Yer*, 3,2k in 900AD), Bakla (3,4k in 900AD), Tepe-Kermen (2,4k), Kachi-Kalyon (2,1k), Kyz-Kermen (1,8k in 800AD) and Kalamita (Inkerman, 2k) [26][27][28]. Total population recovered from 125k in 500AD to 140k in 600AD and 160k in 700AD.

In the eighth and ninth centuries AD, Khazar rule over eastern and foothill Crimea (governed by a Khazar *tudun* at Bosporos, Sugdaia and at times Cherson) brought a wave of rural settlement studied by I. A. Baranov and A. I. Aibabin [29][30]. Proto-Bulgarian and Alanic herders settled in more than 260 open

villages, pottery centres and vineyards of the Saltovo-Mayaki culture. Sugdaia (Sudak) grew into a major Black Sea port (7,5k in 800AD and 9k in 900AD), flanked by the 18 ha coastal town and monastery of Tepsen (Koktebel, 3,4k in 900AD), Kordon-Oba (1,8k), Otuz (Shchebetovka, 1,4k), Geroevskoye and Ptashkino on the Kerch Peninsula [29][31]. In Byzantine Cherson (made capital of the *Theme of Klimata/Cherson* under Emperor Theophilos in 833/841AD), the town population reached 11,5k - 12k in 800-900AD [32][33]. Crimea's population climbed to 195k in 800AD and 215k in 900AD (74k in the south-west, 36k on the south coast, 77k in the east and 28k in the north-west).

Kievan Rus and the Cumans

Pecheneg raids across the steppe (c. 900-960AD) and Prince Svyatoslav Igorevich's overthrow of the Khazar Khaganate (965AD) ruined many open Saltovo-Mayaki villages in eastern Crimea and on the Kerch steppe (including Tepsen and Kordon-Oba), bringing the population down to 190k in 1000AD and 185k in 1100AD [29][34]. At the same time, Kievan Rus gained a direct foothold on the peninsula.

In 988-989AD Grand Prince Vladimir Svyatoslavich besieged and took Byzantine Cherson (*Korsun*), was baptised there, married the princess Anna Porphyrogenita and handed the city back to Emperor Basil II [32][33]. Through the eleventh and twelfth centuries, Korsun (10k in 1000AD; 8k - 8,5k in 1100-1200AD) remained the main port for trade between Byzantium and Rus. Across the Kerch Strait, the Rurikid princes of Tmutarakan (988-1094AD) ruled Korchev (ancient Bosporos/Kerch, 7,5k in 1000AD; 6,5k - 7k in 1100-1200AD), as recorded on Prince Gleb Svyatoslavich's 1068AD *Tmutarakan Stone*, which measured the 14k-fathom distance across the frozen strait from Tmutarakan to Korchev [34].

By 1200AD, lively trade between the Cumans (Polovtsians), the Empire of Trebizond and the Seljuk Turks of Rum lifted Sugdaia (*Surozh* in Russian chronicles) to 11k inhabitants as the chief silk and fur port on the northern Black Sea. The mountain towns of Gothia also grew (Mangup at 7k, Eski-Kermen at 4,8k, Chufut-Kale at 3,8k, Bakla at 3k, Aluston at 3,5k and Gorzouvitai at 2,8k), carrying the Crimean total back to 205k [28][33].

The Golden Horde, Genoese Gazaria and Theodoro

Mongol horsemen under Jebe and Subutai raided Sugdaia in January 1223AD, Batu conquered the Crimean steppe in 1238-1239AD and Nogai sacked Korsun, Eski-Kermen, Bakla and Sugdaia in 1299AD [33][35]. Although the initial Mongol attacks reduced the population from 195k in 1240AD to 175k in 1250AD, Crimea soon prospered as the chief Black Sea outlet of the Golden Horde (*Ulus of Jochi*), and by 1300AD the peninsula reached an all-time pre-modern peak of 250k.

Built in the sheltered Agarmysh valley of eastern Crimea as the seat of the Golden Horde governor (*tumen-bashi*), Solkhat (*Qirim*, which gave its name to the whole peninsula) grew into a 300 ha walled city with mosques, madrasas, Armenian and Greek churches, caravanserais, mints and clay water pipes [35][36][37]. At its height in 1300-1340AD, Solkhat held 28k inhabitants (18k in 1400AD), alongside the inland market town of Karasubazar (Bilohirsk, 8k in 1300AD and 7,5k in 1400AD) and the cliff-top fortress of Chufut-Kale (*Qirq-Yer*) and Eski-Yurt/Salachik in the Bakhchisaray valley (5,5k and 3,5k in 1300-1400AD) [38][39][40][41].

On the coast, after Mengu-Timur Khan granted trading rights at ancient Theodosia in 1266AD, the Genoese built Caffa (Feodosia) into a 90 ha double-walled port inhabited by Armenians, Greeks, Italians, Tatars, Jews and Rus [37][42][43][44]. Before the Black Death broke out during Janibeg Khan's siege of 1346AD, Caffa held 32k - 40k people, lifting eastern Crimea as a whole to 96k in 1300AD. Genoa also took over Cembalo (Balaklava, 1343/1357AD, 2,2k in 1300AD and 2,5k in 1400AD), Soldaia (Sudak, 1365AD, with 18 coastal villages, 12k in 1300AD and 6,5k in 1400AD), Vosporo (Kerch, 5,5k in 1300AD and 4,5k in 1400AD) and the castles of the *Capitanate of Gotthia* along the southern coast (Aluston/*Lusta* at 4k,

Gorzouvitai at 3,2k, Partenit at 2,6k, Jalita/Yalta at 3k and Foros at 1,6k) [28][31][44][45].

In the south-western mountains and the Belbek, Kacha and Chorna valleys, the Greek-Gothic princes of Theodoro enlarged the citadel and walls of Mangup (8,5k in 1300AD and 9k in 1400AD), built the port fort of Kalamita (Inkerman, 2,5k in 1400AD) opposite Genoese Cembalo and fortified the border castle of Funa at the foot of Mount Demerdzhi alongside Syuyren, Kermenchik and Chorgun [27][28][35].

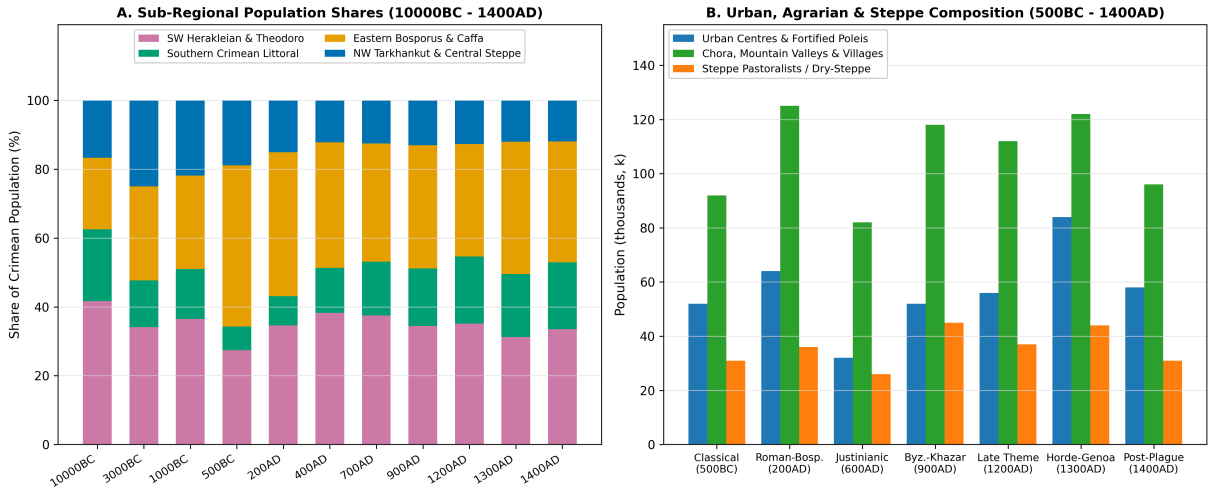


Figure 3. Shifts in regional weight and town-to-countryside balance across Crimea from 1000BC to 1400AD, contrasting the heavy rural settlement of the Bosporan and Khazar eras with the high urban share of the fourteenth-century Italian and Tatar trading cities.

The Black Death and the 1400AD Benchmark

Repeated outbreaks of plague after the 1346AD siege of Caffa, civil war in the Golden Horde during the *Great Troubles* (1359-1380AD) and the campaigns of Timur (1395-1396AD) and Edigu (who burned the last inhabited quarters of Korsun in 1399AD) cut Crimea's population from 250k in 1300AD to 185k in 1400AD (62k in the south-west, 36k on the south coast, 65k in the east and 22k in the north-west). By 1400AD the main towns stood at 22k for Caffa, 18k for Solkhat, 9k for Mangup, 7,5k for Karasubazar, 6,5k for Soldaia, 5,5k for Qirq-Yer, 4,5k for Vosporo, 2,5k for Cembalo and 2k for Korsun [35][42][46][47].

Regional Population Summary

Table 2 sets out the population estimates for Crimea (~26,95k km^2) and its four regions from 10000BC to 1400AD.

Year	SW & Theodoro	South Coast	East & Bosporus	NW & Steppe	Total Pop.	Historical & Archaeological Context
10000BC	0,5k	0,25k	0,25k	0,2k	1,2k	Upper Palaeolithic/Early Shan-Koba Grottoes (Kiik-Koba, Siuren I, Buran-Kaya III)
8000BC	0,85k	0,45k	0,45k	0,35k	2,1k	Boreal Shan-Koba Mesolithic Foragers (Shan-Koba, Fatma-Koba, Grot Skalisty)

6000BC	1,4k	0,75k	0,75k	0,6k	3,5k	Atlantic Murzak-Koba Mesolithic & Early Neolithic (Murzak-Koba, Laspi VII, Zamil-Koba)
5000BC	2,5k	1,2k	1,5k	1,3k	6,5k	Crimean Neolithic Expansion (Tash-Air I, Kaya-Arasy, Frontovoye I, At-Bash)
4000BC	4k	1,8k	2,8k	2,4k	11k	Eneolithic Steppe & Foothill Pastoralism (Sredny Stog & Early Copper Age)
3000BC	7,5k	3k	6k	5,5k	22k	Early Bronze Age Kemi-Oba Megalithic & Yamnaya Cultures (Kemi-Oba, Bakhchi-Eli)
2000BC	12k	4,5k	9,5k	9k	35k	Middle Bronze Age Catacomb & Late Kemi-Oba Settlements (Kamenka, Planerskoye)
1000BC	17,5k	7k	13k	10,5k	48k	Late Bronze/Early Iron Age Tauri Kizil-Koba Culture (Uch-Bash, Kizil-Koba)
500BC	48k	12k	82k	33k	175k	Archaic-Classical Greek Colonisation (Panticapaeum, Chersonesus, Theodosia, Kerkinitis)
0AD	72k	16k	88k	34k	210k	Hellenistic-Roman Transition & Late Scythian State (Scythian Neapolis, Ust-Alma)
200AD	78k	19k	94k	34k	225k	Roman Garrison & Bosporan Peak (Charax, Chersonesus 20k, Panticapaeum 28k)
300AD	56k	16k	61k	22k	155k	Post-Gothic Raid Contraction (Destruction of Tanais, Ilurat & Scythian Foothill Forts)
400AD	44k	15k	42k	14k	115k	Post-Hunnic Low Point (370-376AD Collapse of Bosporan Chora & Flight into Mountains)
500AD	48k	18k	44k	15k	125k	Early Byzantine Reconquest under Anastasius & Justinian I (Aluston, Gorzouvitai, Doros)

600AD	54k	21k	48k	17k	140k	Byzantine Rule & Rise of Gothic Cave-Towns (Mangup, Eski-Kermen, Chufut-Kale)
700AD	60k	25k	55k	20k	160k	Early Khazar Rule & Crimean Tudunate (Cherson, Bosporos, Sugdaia)
800AD	68k	32k	70k	25k	195k	Saltovo-Mayaki Village Expansion (260+ Eastern & Foothill Villages, Tepsen)
900AD	74k	36k	77k	28k	215k	Byzantine Theme of Klimata/Cherson & Khazar Peak (Cherson 12k, Sugdaia 9k)
1000AD	68k	34k	64k	24k	190k	Kievan Rus Korsun Campaign (988AD) & Tmutarakan-Korchev Principality (Post-Khazar Shift)
1100AD	65k	35k	61k	24k	185k	Cuman (Polovtsian) Steppe Rule & Byzantine-Rus Trade at Korsun and Korchev
1200AD	72k	40k	67k	26k	205k	Pre-Mongol Commercial Recovery (Sugdaia/ Surozh 11k, Mangup 7k, Korsun 8k)
1240AD	69k	38k	64k	24k	195k	Initial Mongol Raids (1223AD & 1238-1239AD Steppe Campaigns)
1250AD	63k	35k	56k	21k	175k	Post-Conquest Transition & Early Golden Horde Rule
1300AD	78k	46k	96k	30k	250k	Golden Horde Solkhat (28k) & Genoese Caffa (32k) Commercial Peak (despite 1299AD Raid)
1400AD	62k	36k	65k	22k	185k	Post-1346AD Black Death, Horde Civil Wars & 1395-1399AD Timur/ Edigu Raids; Theodoro Peak

Table 2. Complete population series for Crimea and its four regions at 25 benchmark dates, paired with the main archaeological cultures and historical turning points behind each shift.

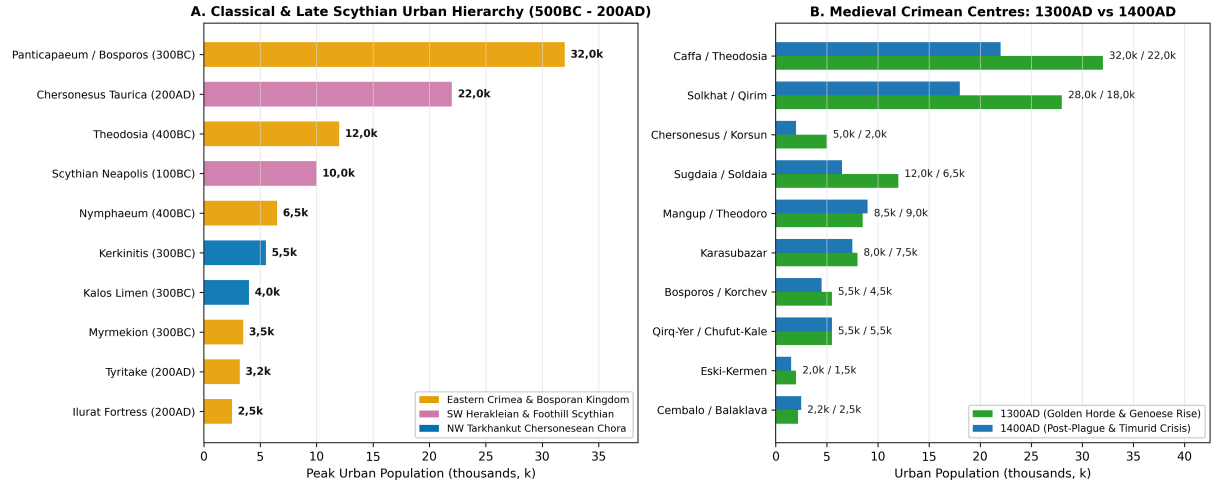


Figure 4. Estimated populations of Crimea's leading cities in Classical antiquity (500BC - 200AD, left) and the late Middle Ages (1300 - 1400AD, right), led by Panticapaeum (28k) and Chersonesus (20k) in the Roman era and by Genoese Caffa (32k) and Golden Horde Solkhat (28k) before the Black Death.

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